

MD-0006: Assertion Discipline for VIDS Artifacts and Generators

Field	Value
ID	MD-0006
Type	MD, Maintainer Decision
Status	Accepted
Normative?	No. Records a governance rule constraining what project artifacts and tools may emit; it does not itself define a dataset requirement.
Visibility	Public (standard governance)
Proposed date	2026-07-27
Accepted date	2026-07-31
Deciders	Steering Committee / maintainers (Princeton Medical Systems)
Related	GOVERNANCE.md §1; SPEC.md §11.1 (quality/quality_summary.json, whose example block carries the certification fields); SPEC.md §8.2 (Imaging Sidecar JSON, containing the DeIdentification block); MD-0001; MD-0005; MD-0007; CONTRIBUTING.md

Decision

- Rule 1, outcome-claim vocabulary.** VIDS artifacts and tools must not emit certification, attestation, approval, assurance or equivalent outcome claims about a dataset unless an adopted governance decision expressly authorizes that claim. This rule binds dataset-facing outputs: specification text, worked examples, generator output, schema fields, validator output, and public project surfaces.
- Rule 2, provenance population.** A generator may populate a provenance field only when the act that field denotes is the act the generator just performed. A generator may transcribe a value from a source record when that source is identified in the resulting record. Transcription does not constitute verification. When neither condition applies, the generator must emit a placeholder or an approved recording-state sentinel.
- Both rules bind at the field, not at the tool.** Compliance is evaluated per populated field against the act that field denotes. A tool that performed some act is not thereby licensed to populate fields denoting other acts.
- No authorization route is created by this decision.** Rule 1 permits an outcome claim only where a separate adopted governance decision expressly authorizes it. No such decision currently exists, and this decision does not create a general one. In particular, no claim may be justified on the ground that it was "independently established under the governing process": no such process exists.
- Governance sign-off records are outside Rule 1.** Approval blocks, signature copies and acceptance records for governance artifacts (MD, CN, SOP, REG, minutes) record who accepted a project decision. They make no claim about a dataset and are not dataset-facing outputs.

Rationale

The conformance boundary, that VIDS verifies documentation is present and structured and never certifies a dataset, has been carried in practice rather than in the record. Verification on 2026-07-27 confirmed that MD-0001 through MD-0004 establish no vocabulary rule of any kind. Practice is not enforceable and does not survive contributor turnover, which is why certification language reached the specification, the worked examples, the scaffolding generator and the public site simultaneously and stayed there through review. This decision moves the discipline from habit into the record so that a reviewer has a rule to cite.

Rule 2 is bound at the field rather than the generator because a generator-level formulation does not catch the observed defect. The LIDC pipeline had genuinely just performed a format conversion, so any test asking "did this tool perform an act?" returns true and lets a wrongly populated de-identification date through. The question that catches it is narrower: does this specific field denote the act just performed? Field-level binding is the operative difference between a rule that works and one that reads well.

The alternative considered and set aside was to treat each occurrence as an isolated editorial defect and correct the four locations. That was rejected because it leaves the root cause untouched: with no rule in the record, the language returns on the next artifact that nobody thought to check.

Rule 1 is fenced to dataset-facing outputs so the decision does not breach itself. MD-0001 through MD-0004 each carry a sign-off table recording approval, and an unfenced Rule 1 would place the adopting instrument in violation on the day it is accepted.

Application

This decision governs the following corrections, which ship as one erratum release alongside MD-0007:

Artifact	Location	Correction
SPEC.md	lines 811-812, §11.1	Remove <code>CertificationStatement</code> and <code>CertifiedBy</code> from the example block.
EXAMPLES.md	lines 344-345	Remove the certification block sitting beneath <code>ValidationStatus: PASS</code> .
tools/vids_init.py	lines 341-342	Remove <code>CertificationStatement</code> and <code>CertifiedBy</code> . <code>Date: today</code> pre-stamps an event the generator did not perform.
tools/vids_init.py	line 222	<code>ConversionDate: today</code> becomes <code>TODO</code> . The generator did not perform the conversion; <code>ConversionTool</code> beside it is already <code>TODO</code> .
tools/vids_init.py	line 233	<code>DeIdentification.Date: today</code> becomes <code>TODO</code> , matching the three sibling fields.
tools/vids_init.py	line 263	<code>AnnotationProcess.Date: today</code> becomes <code>TODO</code> . The generator did not perform the annotation.
tools/vids_init.py	line 84	<code>_placeholder_provenance</code> writes <code>Date: date_str</code> from today. Becomes a placeholder, and the now-unused parameter is dropped. Every sibling field in that helper already carries a <code>TODO</code> prefix; the date was the only one given a real value.
tools/vids_init.py	line 323	<code>QualityAssessmentDate: today</code> becomes <code>TODO</code> . No quality assessment was performed.

Artifact	Location	Correction
tests/ test_assertion_discipline.py	new	Five tests. Rule 1: no outcome-claim field in any scaffolded JSON, and annotator <code>Credentials</code> survive. Rule 2: no date on a foreign-act field, no occurrence of today's date outside <code>Created</code> and <code>LastModified</code> , and placeholders remain present so A004 and A005 still pass.
.github/workflows/ci.yml	unit-test step	Remove <code>continue-on-error: true</code> . While it is set, a failing test does not fail the build, so these tests report rather than enforce.
vidsstandard.org	site-wide	Replace "Validation Attestation". Ships with this decision, or the site is corrected twice.
VALIDATION_RULES.md	line 60, Conformance Boundary	Remove "audit" from "downstream review, procurement, or audit workflows". Included as adjacent editorial cleanup, not as a Rule 1 remediation: see Scope.

Change taxonomy: governance-directed (specification, documentation, website) plus defect-fix (generator). Per the registered taxonomy, governance-directed applies because these artifacts were permissible until Rule 1 was adopted; the generator's auto-populated provenance date is tagged separately as a defect.

Do not touch. The following are outside Rule 1 and must survive the correction intact. A contributor implementing this decision by searching for certification vocabulary will match all of them.

Artifact	Location	Why it stays
SPEC.md	line 288	"PrimaryAnnotator": "Board-certified thoracic radiologist". Describes a person's professional credentials, not a claim about the dataset.
EXAMPLES.md	lines 138, 367	Annotator <code>Credentials</code> . Same reason.
QUICKSTART.md	line 179	Annotator <code>Credentials</code> . Same reason.
README.md	line 122	Annotator <code>Credentials</code> . Same reason.
tools/vids_init.py	line 257	Annotator <code>Credentials</code> placeholder. Same reason.
SPEC.md	line 1015	Backward Compatibility Guarantee and its 2026-07-09 erratum. A commitment about validator behavior across versions, not an outcome claim about a dataset.
CONTRIBUTING.md	lines 101, 103	Backward Compatibility Guarantee heading and text. Same reason.

Rule 1 governs claims a VIDS artifact makes about a dataset. Recording an annotator's credentials states who performed an act; it asserts nothing about the dataset's fitness. Removing those fields would delete provenance the standard exists to capture.

Conformance impact is nil, and this is what keeps the correction off the heavyweight path. Verified 2026-07-27 against repository main: no validation rule references the certification fields. `VALIDATION_RULES.md` mentions `quality/quality_summary.json` at one location only, Q002, which tests the file's existence and nothing within it.

Removing the two fields changes no validation outcome for any dataset. The correction is an erratum, not a rule change, and the pull request must record that finding.

Scope note on the generator. Line 233 was the site that prompted this decision; a sweep during implementation found five. Four of them (lines 222, 263, 84 and 323) were not in the original scope and are listed above. The Ops-doc record of "three confirmed instances in `vids_init.py` and the LIDC pipeline" undercounts `vids_init.py` alone. The remaining today uses at lines 137, 138 and 197 are correct: they record file creation and the scaffold's own changelog entry, both acts the generator performs.

Verification record, closed 2026-07-27. The nil finding was confirmed against the shipped artifact, not against a repository copy or a documentation record.

Item	Value
Artifact	<code>vids_validator/validator.py</code> , from <code>vids_validator-1.2.1-py3-none-any.whl</code>
Source	PyPI, package <code>vids-validator</code> , release 1.2.1, uploaded 2026-06-09
MD5	32462465a70eaf8c0025e40b8ec6c400
Reports	ValidatorVersion: 1.2.1 at line 404
CertificationStatement	no occurrence
CertifiedBy	no occurrence
certif (any case)	no occurrence
attest, audit, assurance	no occurrence

The shipped validator contains no reference to either field. Combined with `VALIDATION_RULES.md`, which mentions `quality/quality_summary.json` at one location only (Q002, testing the file's existence and nothing within it), the erratum classification holds.

Path note for the Change Schedule. The Change Schedule records the reference validator as `validate_vids.py` at the repository root. The correct repository path is `validators/validate_vids.py`, which resolves on main and on the governance branch and is byte-identical to the file distributed as `vids_validator/validator.py` in the wheel (same MD5 as recorded above). Correct the directory in the Change Schedule scope line.

The new tests in `tests/` are the enforcement mechanism for Rule 2. Without them the rule is a statement of intent, and while the CI unit-test step carries `continue-on-error` they report rather than enforce. Removing that flag is listed above and is part of this decision's implementation, not a separate improvement.

Scope

This decision covers what VIDS artifacts and tools may assert. It does not:

- Change any dataset-conformance requirement or validation rule. Only SPEC does that, and only through the ratification path in `CONTRIBUTING.md`.
- Cover the semantics of `DeIdentification.Tool` or the §8.2 candidate list. That is MD-0007.

- Constrain governance sign-off records, per clause 5.
- Authorize any outcome claim, per clause 4.
- Depend on MD-0007. Rules 1 and 2 are complete without it. MD-0007 applies Rule 1 to one field, so the dependency runs in that direction only. The two ship as one erratum release for release convenience, not because either requires the other.
- Treat `VALIDATION_RULES.md:60` as a Rule 1 breach. The sentence describes what a third party may find extension fields useful for and then disclaims VIDS validation of them. It asserts nothing about a dataset, so Rule 1 does not reach it. It is corrected in the same release because "audit" is not project vocabulary, and the Conformance Boundary section is the wrong place to seed it. Recorded here so the judgment is deliberate rather than inferred from the correction.
- Address the emptiness WARN work. Q002 is held behind this decision because it targets the §11.1 structure being changed here; S002, Q003 and M002 touch nothing in this scope and proceed.

Consultation & decision record

Item	Record
Review window	Opened 2026-07-27 on proposal; closed 2026-07-30, when the Signature Copy was circulated for execution
Advisory Council opinion	None requested
Method	Consensus; approved by all three seated members without dissent
Vote count (if voted)	Not put to a vote. Unanimous approval of 3 of 3 seated members.
Recusals	None
Dissents	None

Sign-off

Maintainer	Decision	Approval date
Dr. Joan S. Muthu	Approved	2026-07-31
John Shalen R.	Approved	2026-07-31
John Xavier	Approved	2026-07-31

Approval evidence: MD-0006-ApprovalEvidence-2026-07-31.pdf

Signatories are the Steering Committee recorded under MD-0005 clause 2, each holding governance signatory authority under clause 3. MD-0005 was executed 2026-07-28, so that composition was in effect when this decision was signed. Acceptance took effect on the latest date of signature; the execution platform recorded completion of all three signatures at 10:22:38 UTC on 2026-07-31. This rendering contains no signature lines; signatures are held in the approval evidence cited above.

Change log

Date	Change
2026-07-27	Initial draft (Proposed).
2026-07-29	Revised during review: implementation scope, change taxonomy and verification records updated as recorded in the Application section.
2026-07-30	Signature Copy circulated for execution.
2026-07-31	Accepted following approval by Dr. Joan S. Muthu, John Shalen R., and John Xavier.

MD-0006 is a governance decision. It is non-normative with respect to dataset conformance: it changes no VIDS requirement and no validation rule.